

■ By Shankkar Aiyar with Priya Sahgal and Shafi Rahman

It was the Eureka moment for the Congress. A little over 30 minutes after the trust vote was over and just before the results were declared, Congressman Pawan Bansal excitedly shared a scribbled note with party President Sonia Gandhi. Even as she read the note, Kamal Nath and P. Chidambaram, sitting right behind her, leaned across to look and let out a collective “wow” which was caught by Rahul Gandhi right behind. As he whispered the magical 275 figure to his young colleagues, the thrill of the victory, it would seem, was transmitted across the UPA ranks. Victory, though, didn’t come easily. They say a week is a long time in politics and the UPA had to not only keep its flock together for two weeks but weather the gathering storm of unnatural alliances. The combination of Left and Mayawati on one side and the BJP on the other, particularly at the fag end of its tenure, could have led to complete decimation.

Unshackled from the bondage of the Left, the Congress, it would seem, discovered a sense of purpose just when its survival was under dire threat. In the two weeks after the Left pulled the plug on July 8, the party found its core and political relevance as its core team worked round-the-clock to get the arithmetic of its politics in place. The crack team of Ahmed Patel, Pranab Mukherjee, Sharad Pawar, Vayalar Ravi at the centre and chief ministers Vilasrao Deshmukh,

